1. Welcome and Program Overview

Welcome to the Orion Community Solar Program. Orion Community Solar is a fictional subscription program created for demonstration purposes. The program began operating in March 2021 and serves households and small businesses in Verdant County. Members subscribe to a share of a shared solar array located at the Meadowbrook site, which has a total capacity of 4.8 megawatts. Members do not install any equipment on their property; instead, they receive credits on their regular electricity bill in proportion to the energy their share produces.

The program is open to residential customers, small businesses, and non-profit organizations that receive electricity service from Verdant Power & Light. Renters are eligible because the subscription is tied to the electricity account, not the property. As of January 2024 the program has 2,350 active members and a waiting list of about 400 households.

The program is administered by the Orion Energy Cooperative, which is governed by a seven-member board elected by the membership every two years. This handbook explains how enrollment, billing, credits, maintenance, transfers, and member support work.

2. Eligibility and Enrollment

To enroll, an applicant must have an active electricity account with Verdant Power & Light in Verdant County and be at least 18 years old. There is no enrollment fee and no credit check. Applicants complete the online enrollment form, upload a copy of a recent electricity bill, and sign the subscription agreement electronically.

Enrollment requests are processed in the order received. Because the array capacity is limited, new members are placed on a waiting list when all shares are allocated. The typical waiting period in 2023 was between 20 and 45 days. Once a share is assigned, the member receives a welcome email with the subscription start date, which is always the first day of the next billing cycle.

Members may cancel at any time by submitting a cancellation form. Cancellations take effect at the end of the current billing cycle and require 30 days' written notice. Members who cancel within the first 12 months are not charged an early termination fee, but they lose their place on the waiting list if they wish to re-enroll. Low-income households enrolled in the county energy assistance program receive priority placement and a 10 percent bonus credit for the first two years.

3. Billing and Bill Credits

Each month, the Meadowbrook array's output is measured by the utility and allocated to members according to their share size. Members receive a bill credit at the community solar credit rate, which was set at 11.7 cents per kilowatt-hour for 2024. Credits appear as a separate line labeled 'Community Solar Credit' on the Verdant Power & Light bill.

Subscription payments are collected by the Orion Energy Cooperative and are billed separately on the 5th of each month. The subscription price is 90 percent of the value of the credits generated, meaning members save roughly 10 percent on the energy their share produces. Unused credits roll over to the following month. Any credits remaining after the annual true-up, which occurs every March, are paid out by check if the balance exceeds 25 dollars; smaller balances continue to roll over.

Members can view monthly production reports in the member portal. If a payment is more than 60 days late, the subscription may be suspended until the balance is paid. Payment methods include automatic bank withdrawal, credit card, and mailed check. A 3 percent processing fee applies to credit card payments.

4. Subscription Sizing

Subscription shares are measured in kilowatts of array capacity. The minimum share size is 1 kilowatt and the maximum residential share is 25 kilowatts. Small business and non-profit members may subscribe to up to 200 kilowatts. To prevent members from subscribing to more capacity than they can use, a share may not exceed 110 percent of the member's average electricity consumption over the previous 12 months.

For a typical Verdant County household using 900 kilowatt-hours per month, a share of 6 to 7 kilowatts offsets most of the annual usage. The program estimates that each kilowatt of share produces about 1,350 kilowatt-hours per year at the Meadowbrook site.

Members may request a change in share size once per calendar year. Increases depend on available capacity, while decreases are always granted. The sizing calculator in the member portal uses the last 12 months of consumption data from the utility to recommend a share size.

5. Maintenance, Performance and Outages

The Meadowbrook array is maintained by Helios Field Services under a 20-year operations contract. Planned maintenance, including panel cleaning and inverter inspection, is scheduled twice a year, in April and October, and typically reduces output for no more than two days.

The program includes a performance guarantee: if the array produces less than 90 percent of its expected annual output for reasons other than weather, members' subscription payments for that year are reduced proportionally. Unplanned outages lasting more than 24 hours are reported to members by email within 48 hours, and a status page shows live production data. In 2023 the array achieved 96 percent of its expected output.

Severe weather events such as hail are covered by the cooperative's insurance policy, and members are never charged for repairs. Panels are expected to be replaced after about 25 years of service.

6. Moving, Transfers and Account Changes

Members who move within the Verdant Power & Light service territory can keep their subscription by submitting a transfer form with the new service address at least 14 days before the move. There is no transfer fee. Members who move outside the service territory must cancel their subscription because credits can only be applied to accounts with the local utility.

A subscription may be transferred to another person, such as a new homeowner or a family member, provided the recipient is eligible and signs a new subscription agreement. Transfers to another person are limited to one per year.

Name changes, email updates, and payment method changes can be made at any time in the member portal. If a member passes away, the estate may transfer or cancel the subscription without any notice requirement.

7. Member Support and Dispute Resolution

The member support team is available by phone Monday through Friday from 8:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m., and by email at any time. Email inquiries receive a response within two business days.

Billing disputes must be submitted in writing within 60 days of the statement date. The cooperative reviews disputes within 10 business days and issues a written decision. Members who disagree with a decision may request a review by the Member Relations Committee, which meets monthly, and a final appeal may be made to the board of directors. Complaints about the utility's handling of credits should be directed to Verdant Power & Light directly, although the support team can help members prepare the complaint.

The cooperative publishes an annual report every June summarizing production, finances, and member satisfaction survey results. In the 2023 survey, 91 percent of members said they would recommend the program to a neighbor.

8. Glossary and Frequently Asked Questions

Bill credit: the dollar amount subtracted from a member's electricity bill for energy produced by their share. Credit rate: the value per kilowatt-hour assigned to community solar production, set annually by the state utility commission. Share: the portion of the array's capacity, measured in kilowatts, assigned to a member. True-up: the annual reconciliation of credits and payments completed each March.

Can I subscribe if I already have rooftop solar? Yes, as long as your total share does not exceed 110 percent of your remaining usage.

Is the program available in neighboring counties? No. Membership is limited to Verdant Power & Light customers in Verdant County.

What happens during a power outage? Community solar does not provide backup power; your home is still served by the grid.

How was the program funded? The array was financed through a combination of member subscriptions, a state clean energy grant of 3.2 million dollars, and a loan from the Verdant Community Bank.